

Getting Started With the Interactive Decision Template

A STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE

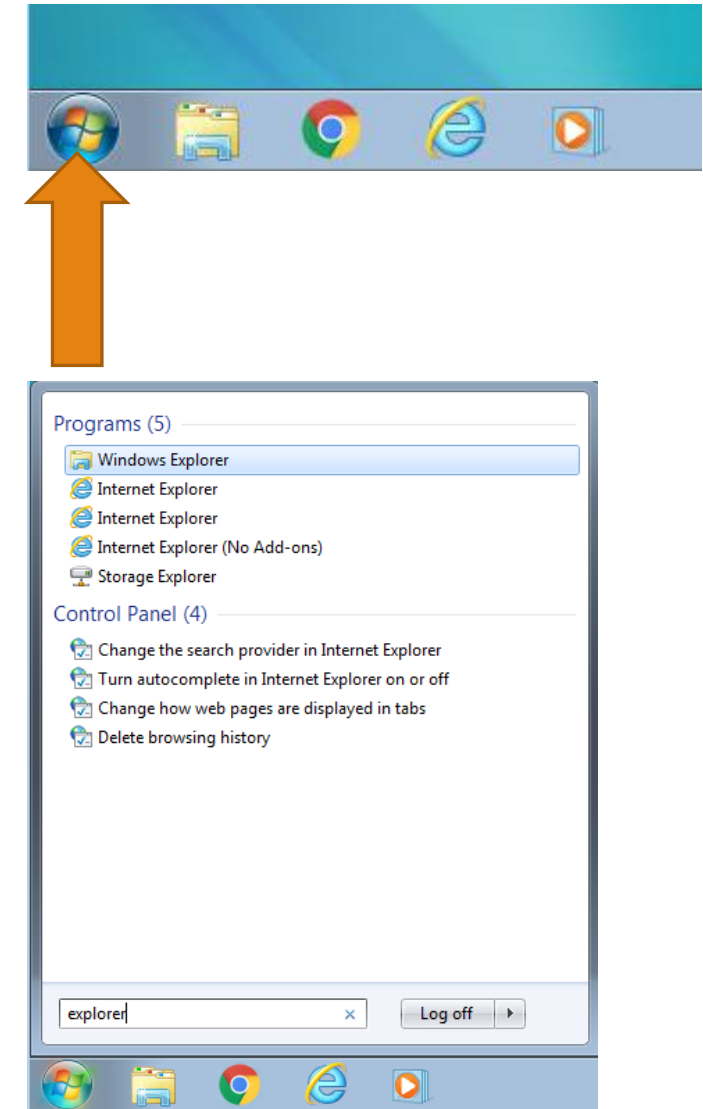
Locating the Interactive Decision Template (IDT)

Open Windows Explorer by clicking on the file folder icon at the bottom of your screen.

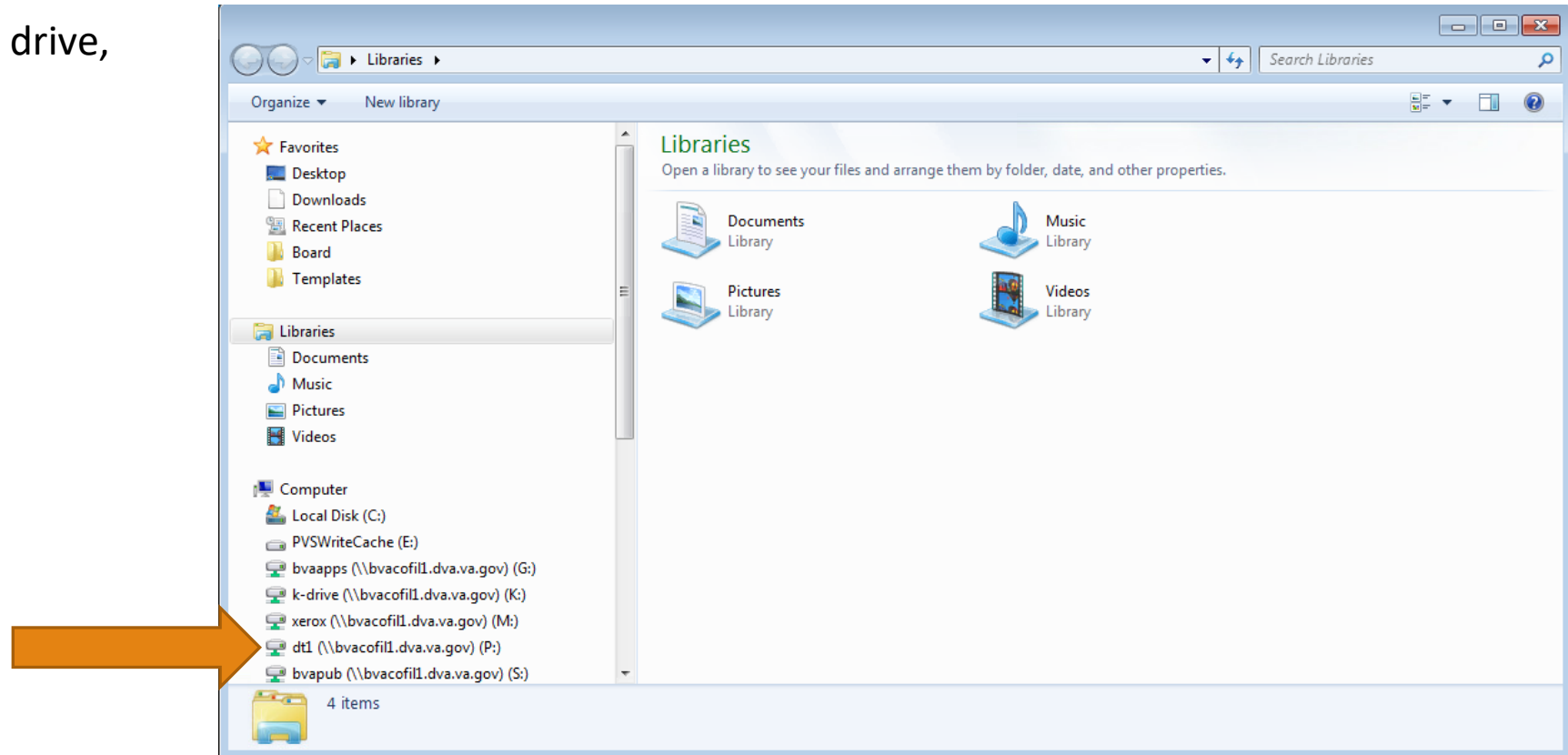


If you don't have a Windows Explorer icon, you can also click on the Start menu.

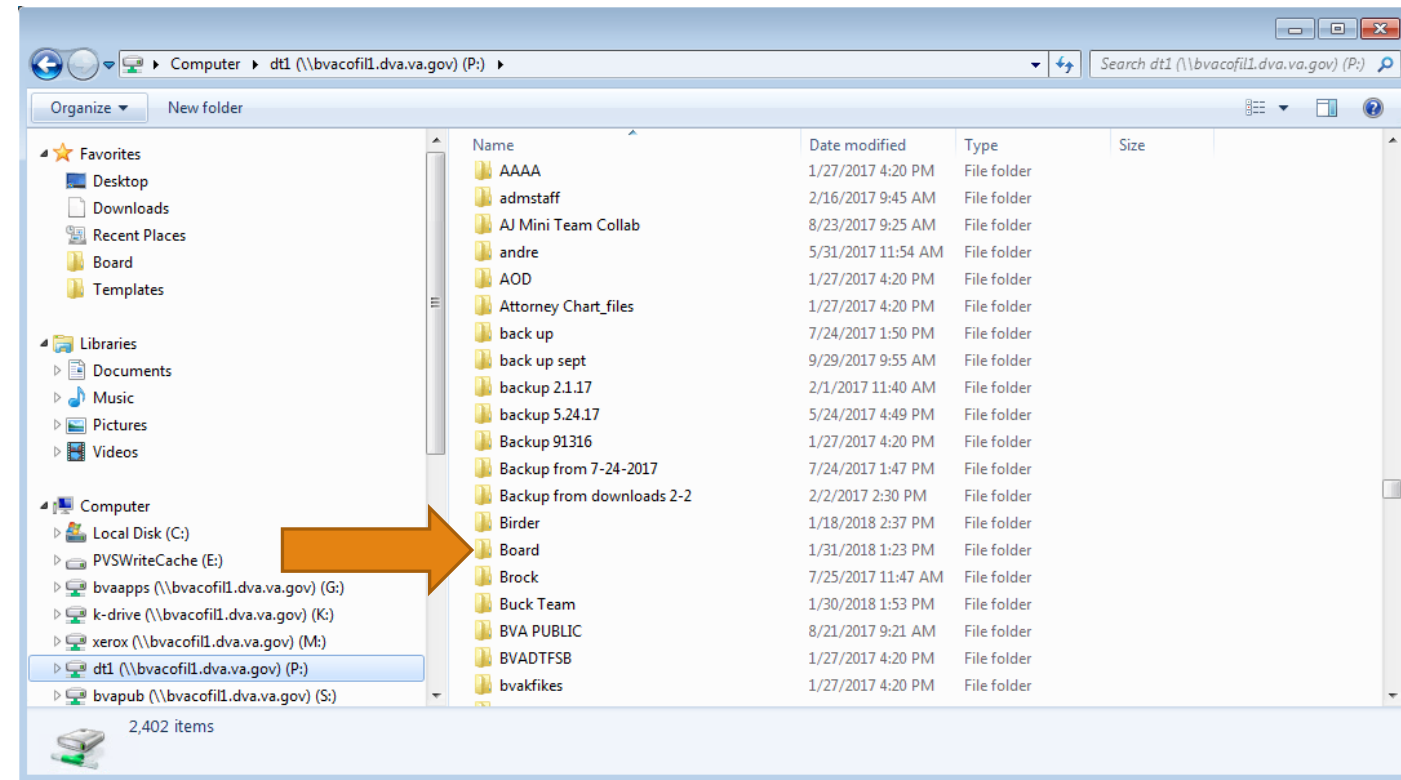
Then type the word "explorer" and click Enter.



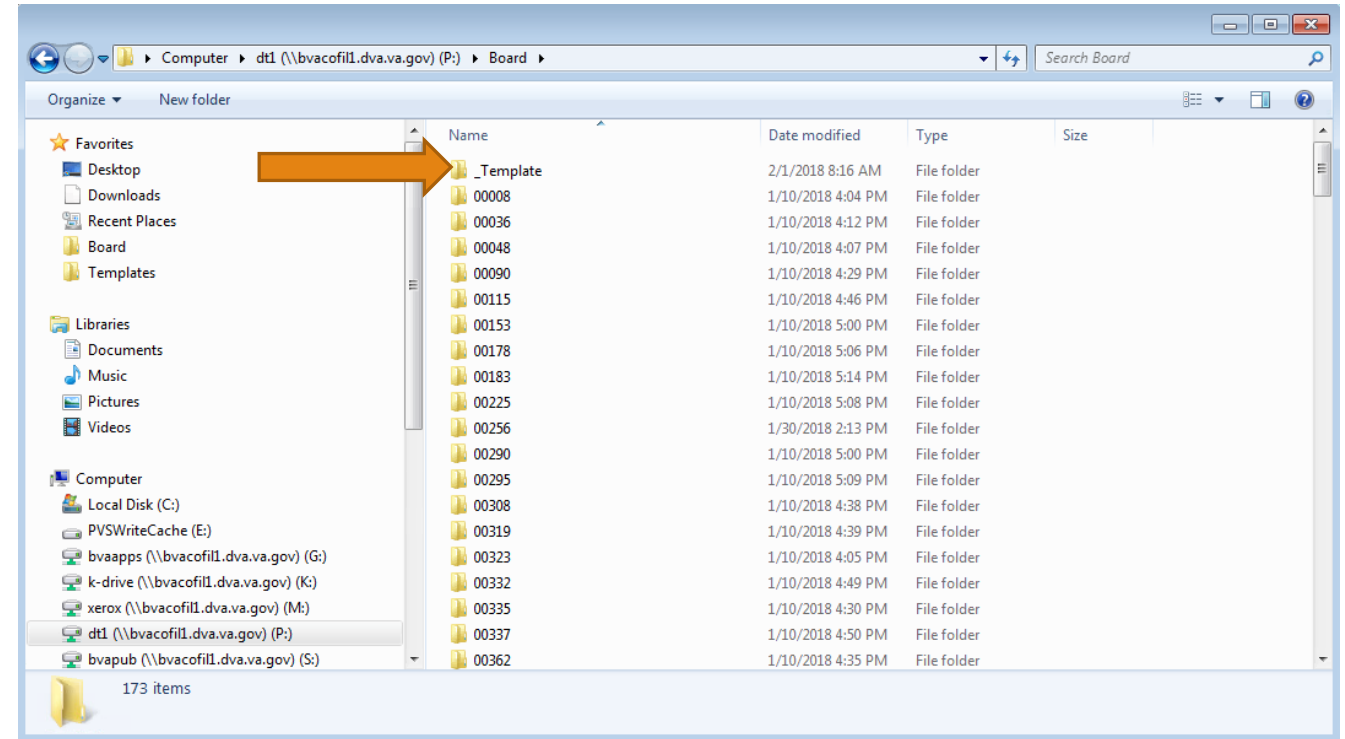
In Windows Explorer, click on your P: drive, which is shown by the arrow here.



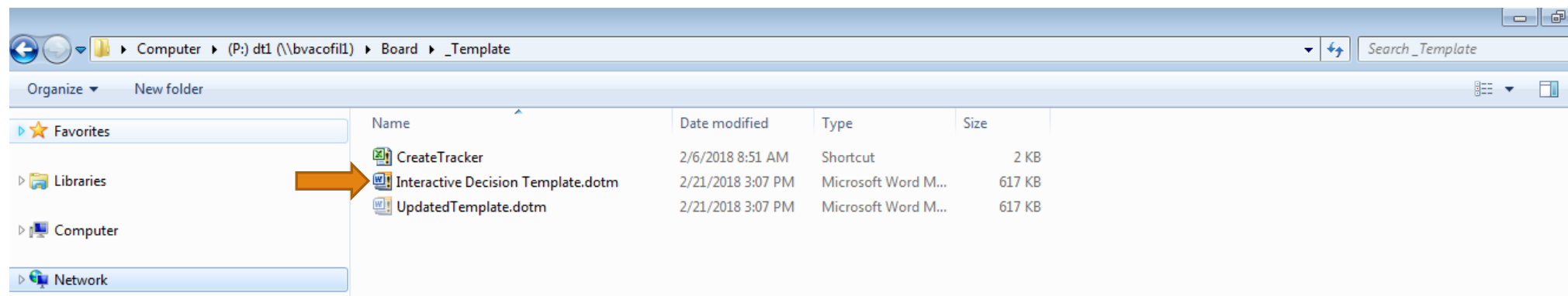
Scroll down to “Board” folder and double click to open it.



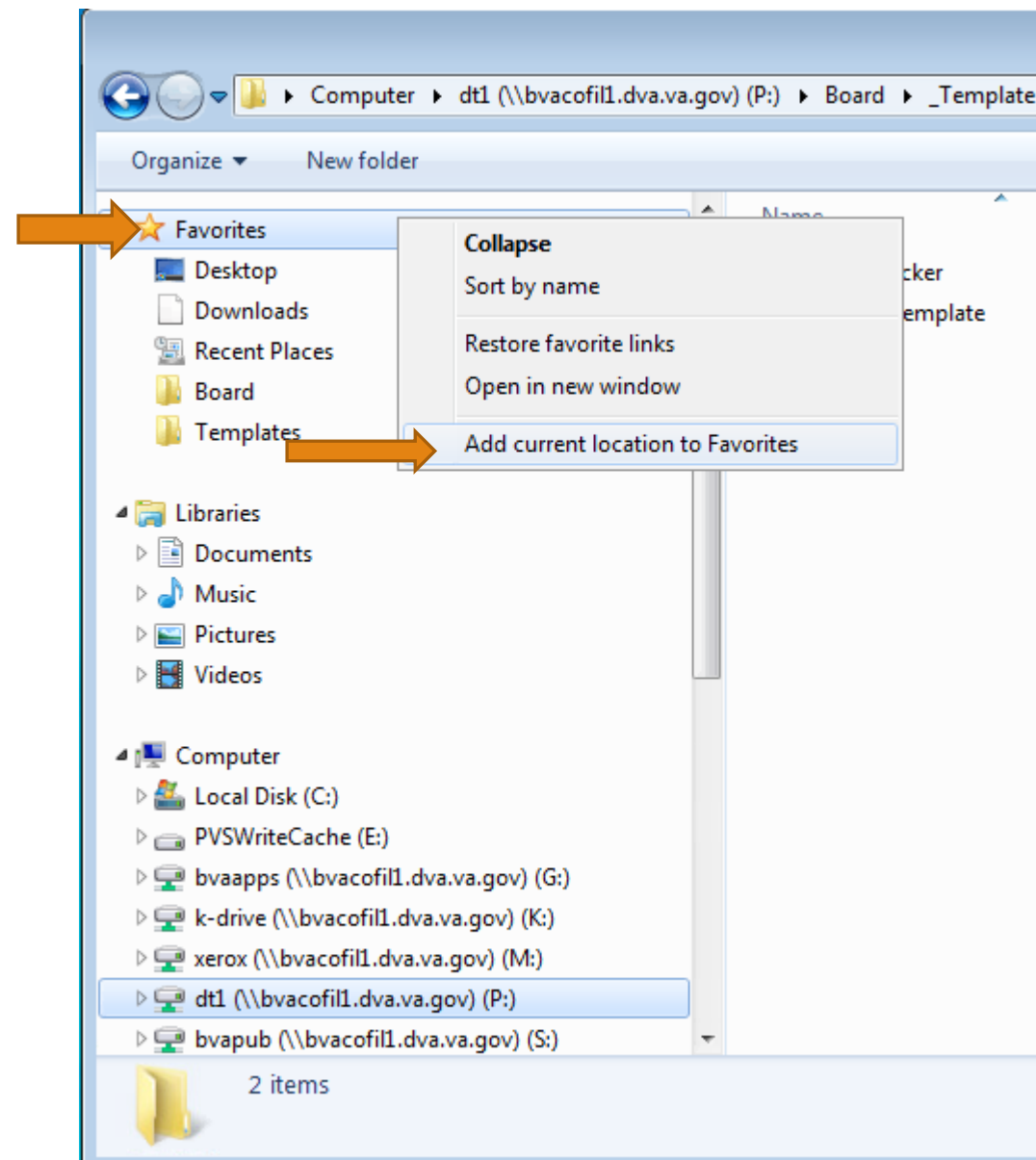
Next, double click on the “_Template” directory. This should be the first folder at the top.



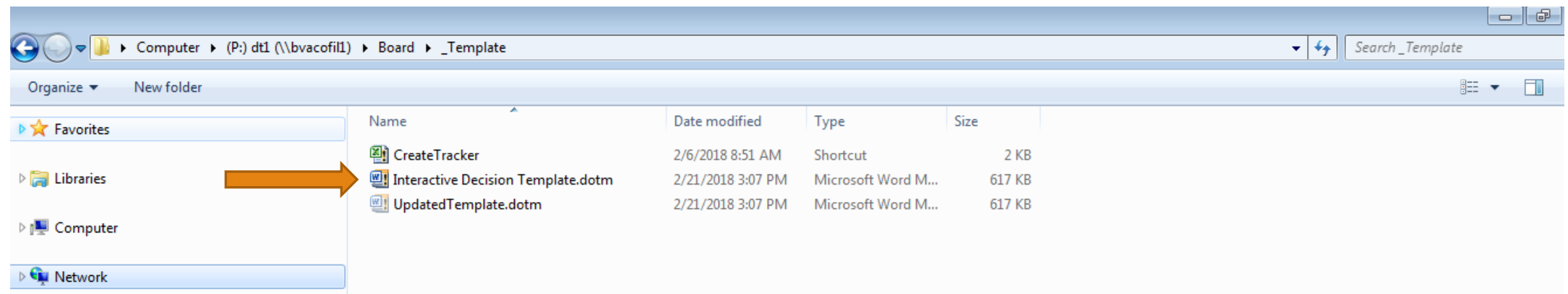
You should see the Interactive Decision Template in this directory.



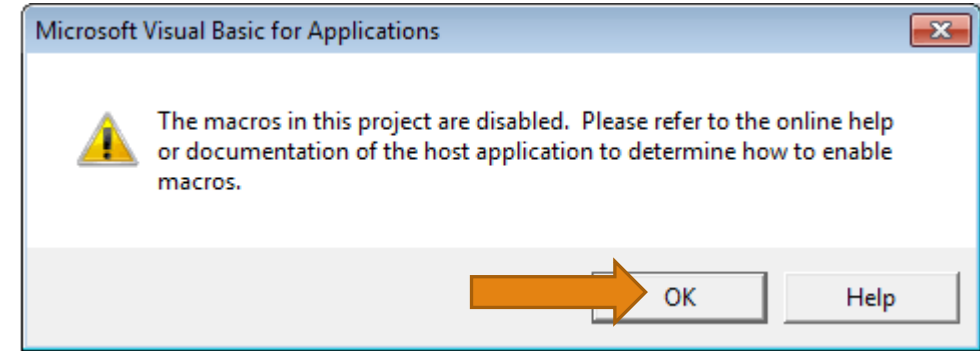
Practice Tip: You can add this directory to your “Favorites” for faster access. To do so, right click on “Favorites” and then click on “Add current location to Favorites”. The “_Template” directory will then show up under the Favorites menu whenever you open Windows Explorer.



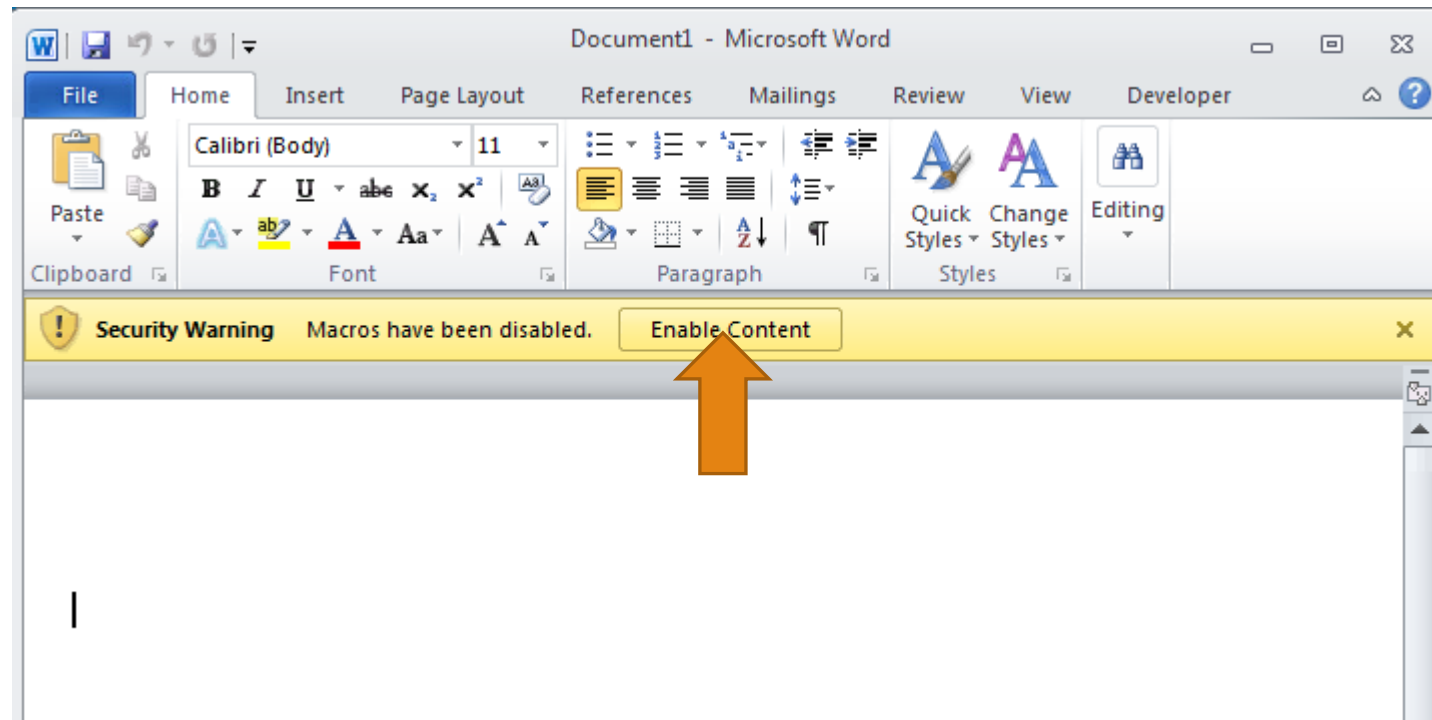
Double click on “Interactive Decision Template” to create a new document with the template.



NOTE: You may see this warning. Do not worry if you do. Click “OK”.



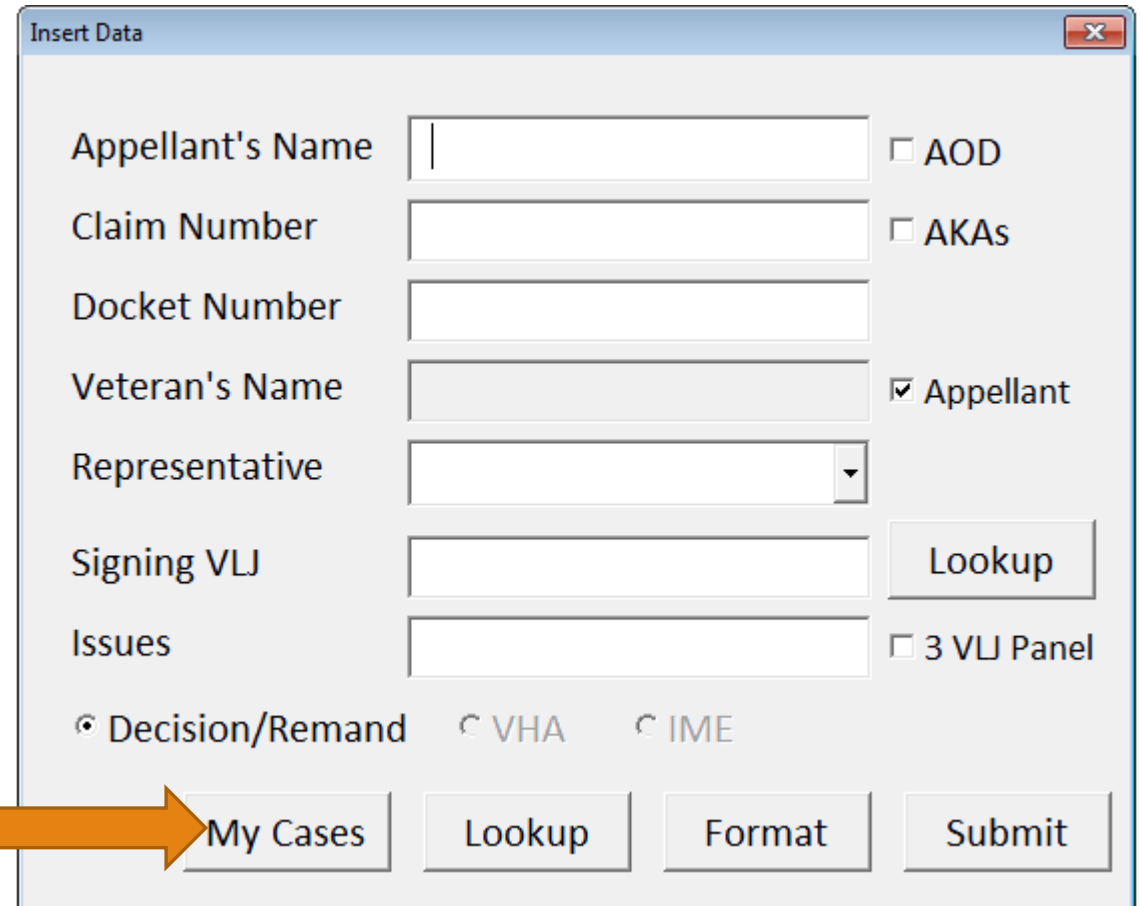
Then click “Enable Content” in the document to start the template.



Auto-populating the IDT

The “Insert Data” screen is the location to input the key information needed to start the drafting process; however, this information does not need to be manually entered.

These fields can be auto populated by VACOLS if you click on “My Cases” at the bottom.



The screenshot shows a web form titled "Insert Data" with a close button (X) in the top right corner. The form contains several input fields and checkboxes:

- Appellant's Name: Text input field.
- Claim Number: Text input field.
- Docket Number: Text input field.
- Veteran's Name: Text input field.
- Representative: Dropdown menu.
- Signing VLJ: Text input field.
- Issues: Text input field.
- Checkboxes on the right: ☐ AOD, ☐ AKAs, ☒ Appellant, ☐ 3 VLJ Panel.
- Radio buttons at the bottom: ☒ Decision/Remand, ☐ VHA, ☐ IME.
- Buttons at the bottom: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit".

An orange arrow points to the "My Cases" button.

This will open a window with the cases currently checked out to you in VACOLS. Click on the claim that you want to write and then click, “Select”.

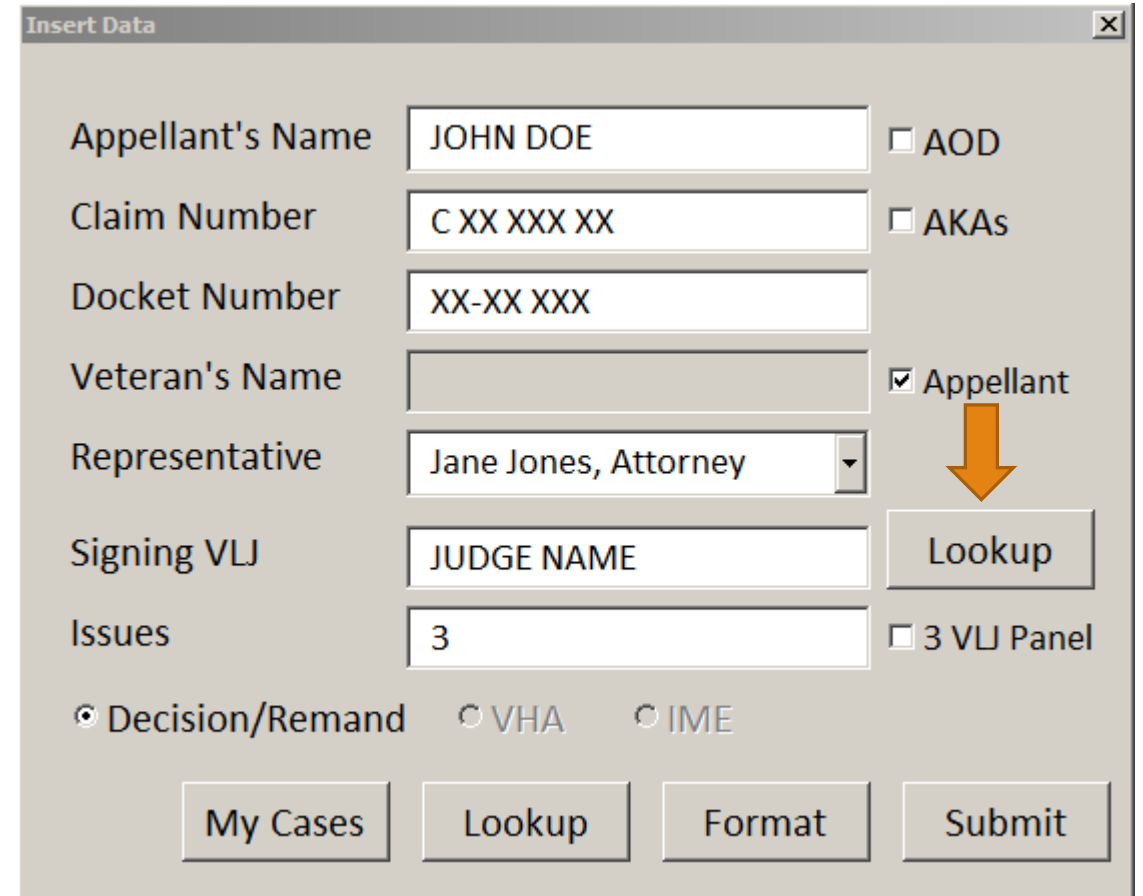


Representative Accreditation Verification

The appropriate fields will be filled in with the information from VACOLS.

NOTE: VACOLS information is not perfect! It is still your responsibility to double check and make corrections to the information contained within the form. Updating this form, does not update VACOLS. Contact your OVLJ Co-located Support Teams for any needed VACOLS updates.

For agent and attorney representatives, you should click on the “Validate” button next to their name to verify their accreditation status.



The screenshot shows a web form titled "Insert Data" with a close button (X) in the top right corner. The form contains several input fields and checkboxes. The fields are: "Appellant's Name" (text box with "JOHN DOE"), "Claim Number" (text box with "C XX XXX XX"), "Docket Number" (text box with "XX-XX XXX"), "Veteran's Name" (text box), "Representative" (dropdown menu with "Jane Jones, Attorney"), "Signing VLJ" (text box with "JUDGE NAME"), and "Issues" (text box with "3"). To the right of these fields are checkboxes for "AOD", "AKAs", "Appellant" (checked), and "3 VLJ Panel". Below the "Appellant" checkbox is a large orange arrow pointing down to a "Lookup" button. At the bottom of the form are four buttons: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit". Radio buttons for "Decision/Remand", "VHA", and "IME" are located below the "Issues" field.

Appellant's Name	JOHN DOE	☐ AOD
Claim Number	C XX XXX XX	☐ AKAs
Docket Number	XX-XX XXX	
Veteran's Name		☒ Appellant
Representative	Jane Jones, Attorney	
Signing VLJ	JUDGE NAME	Lookup
Issues	3	☐ 3 VLJ Panel

☒ Decision/Remand ☐ VHA ☐ IME

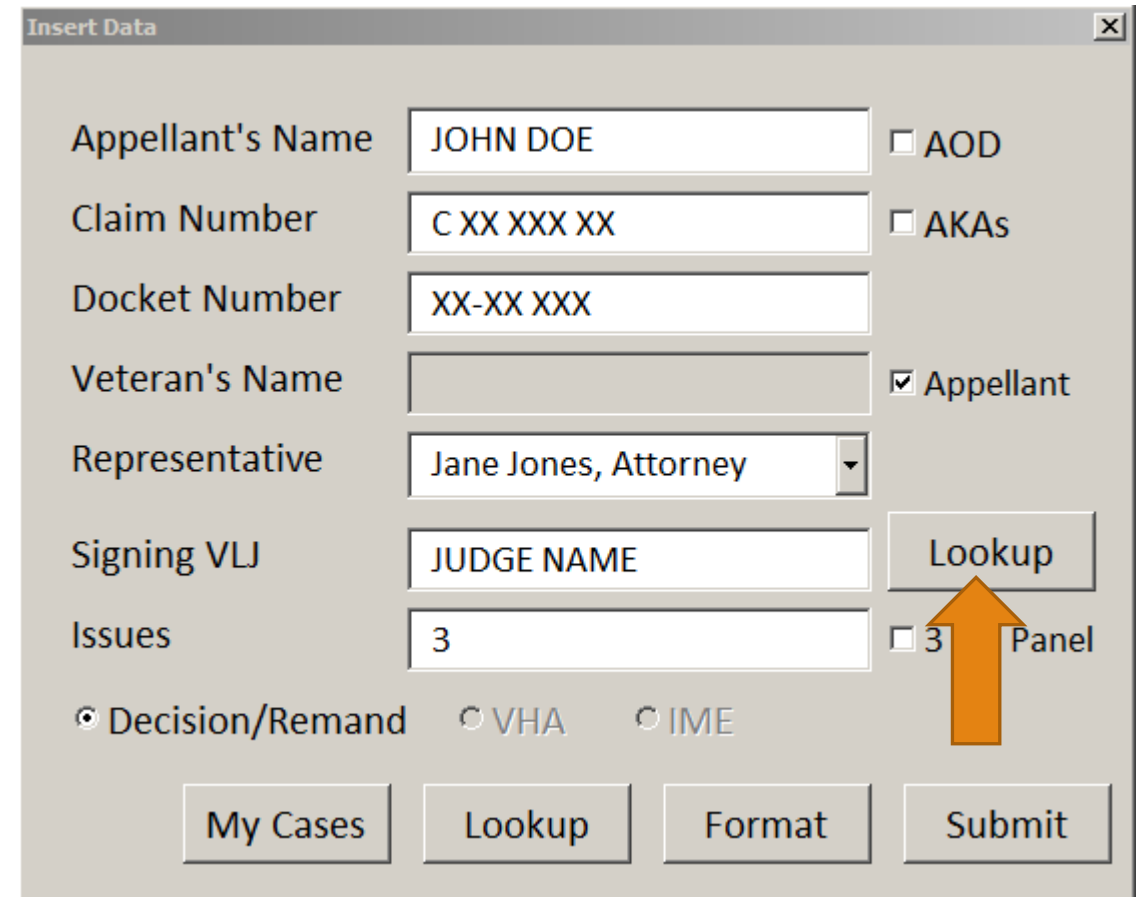
My Cases Lookup Format Submit

The validate button opens a new window to the Attorney or Agent’s listing on the OGC website. If no names show up, the attorney or agent is not registered.



VACOLs assigns the name of the person that checked the case out to you as the signing judge.

If someone other than the person that checked the case out to you should be listed as the signing judge, then you should click the “Lookup” button to list them as the signing VLJ.



The screenshot shows a web form titled "Insert Data" with a close button (X) in the top right corner. The form contains several input fields and checkboxes:

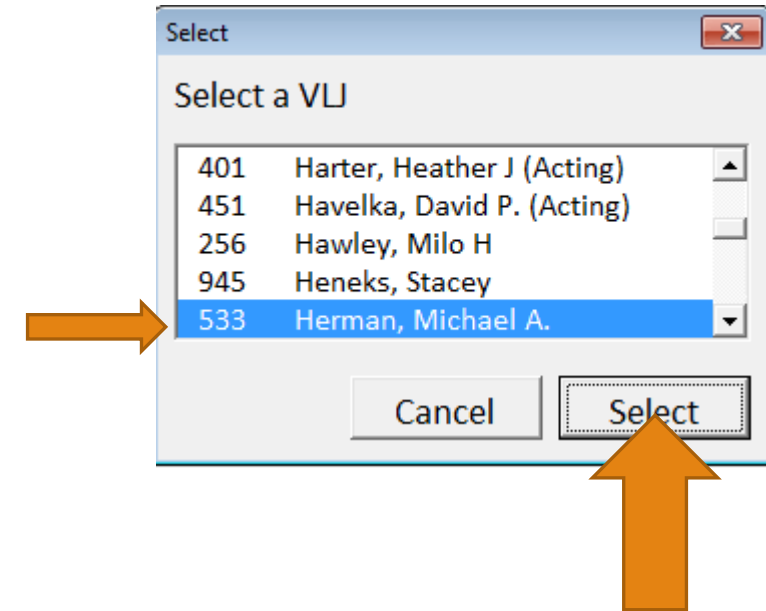
- Appellant's Name:** Text input field containing "JOHN DOE".
- Claim Number:** Text input field containing "C XX XXX XX".
- Docket Number:** Text input field containing "XX-XX XXX".
- Veteran's Name:** Text input field (empty).
- Representative:** Dropdown menu showing "Jane Jones, Attorney".
- Signing VLJ:** Text input field containing "JUDGE NAME".
- Issues:** Text input field containing "3".
- Checkboxes:**
 - ☐ AOD
 - ☐ AKAs
 - ☒ Appellant
 - ☐ 3 Panel
- Radio Buttons:**
 - ☒ Decision/Remand
 - ☐ VHA
 - ☐ IME

At the bottom of the form are four buttons: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit". An orange arrow points to the "Lookup" button, which is positioned to the right of the "Signing VLJ" field.

You will be provided with a list of all the VLJs/ Acting VLJs registered in VACOLs.

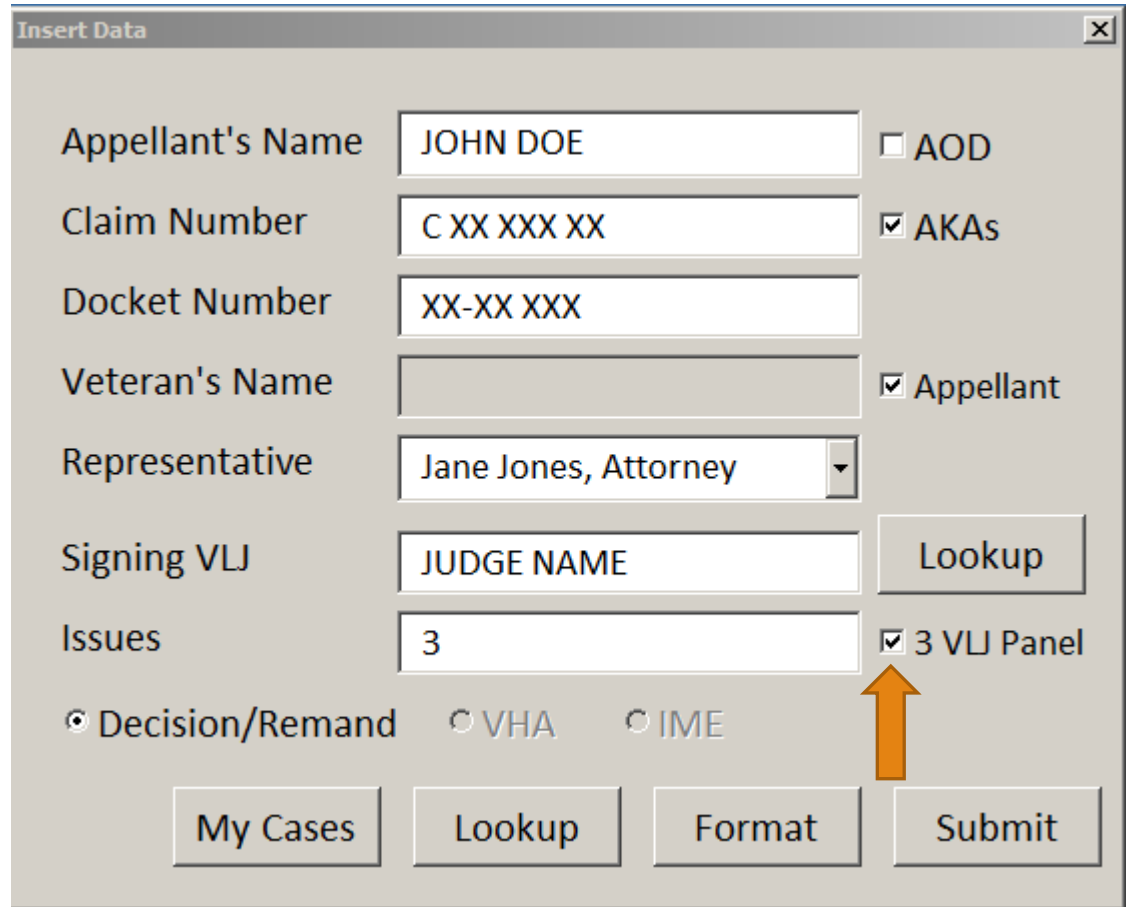
Scroll to the signing VLJ, click on their name to highlight it, and then press the “Select” button.

NOTE: The number to the left of their name is their judge number.



Panel Decisions

If you need to draft a panel decision, click on the “3 VLJ Panel” checkbox. Later you will be asked to select the other judges.



The screenshot shows a web form titled "Insert Data" with a close button (X) in the top right corner. The form contains several input fields and checkboxes. The fields are: "Appellant's Name" (text box with "JOHN DOE"), "Claim Number" (text box with "C XX XXX XX"), "Docket Number" (text box with "XX-XX XXX"), "Veteran's Name" (text box), "Representative" (dropdown menu with "Jane Jones, Attorney"), "Signing VLJ" (text box with "JUDGE NAME"), and "Issues" (text box with "3"). To the right of these fields are checkboxes for "AOD", "AKAs", "Appellant", and "3 VLJ Panel". The "3 VLJ Panel" checkbox is checked and highlighted by an orange arrow. Below the "Issues" field are three radio buttons: "Decision/Remand" (selected), "VHA", and "IME". At the bottom of the form are four buttons: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit". A "Lookup" button is also located to the right of the "Signing VLJ" field.

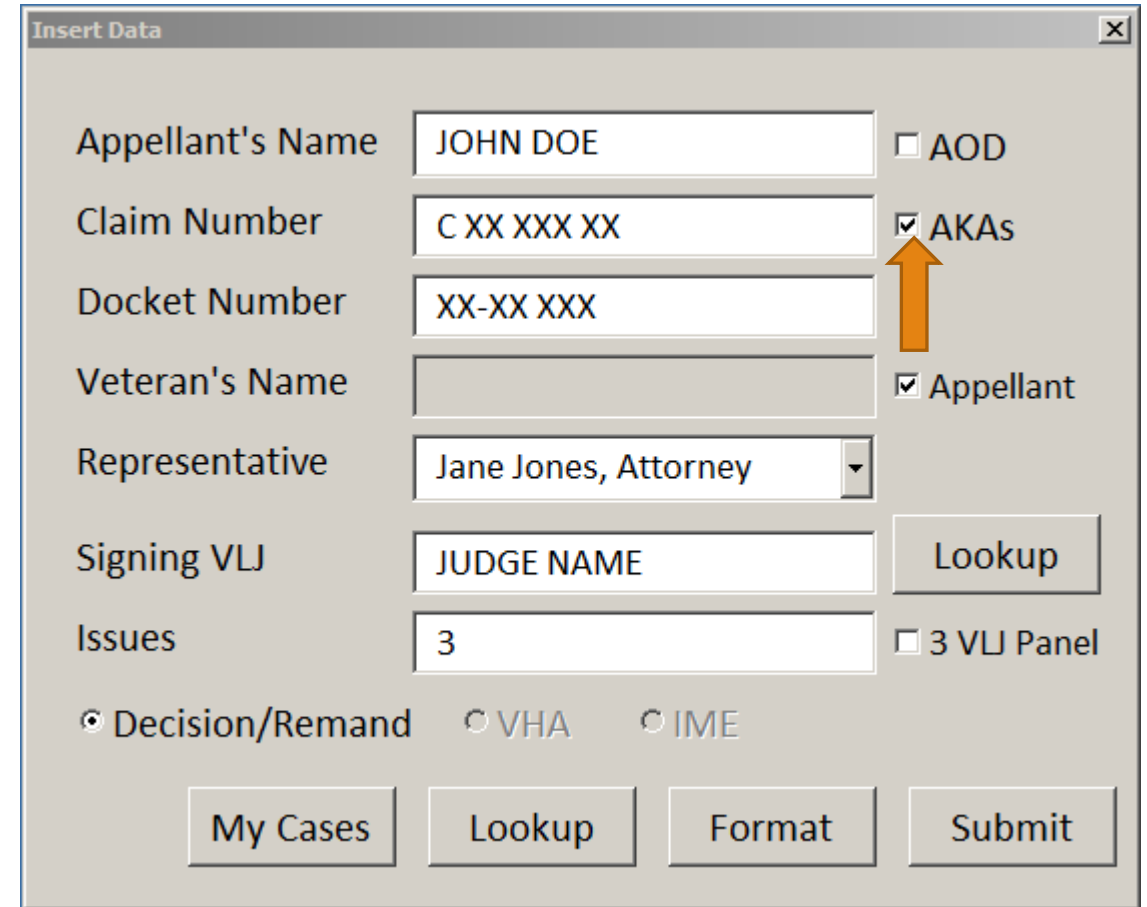
Appellant's Name	JOHN DOE	☐ AOD
Claim Number	C XX XXX XX	☒ AKAs
Docket Number	XX-XX XXX	
Veteran's Name		☒ Appellant
Representative	Jane Jones, Attorney	
Signing VLJ	JUDGE NAME	Lookup
Issues	3	☒ 3 VLJ Panel

☒ Decision/Remand ☐ VHA ☐ IME

My Cases Lookup Format Submit

AKA names

If the appellant has AKAs that you need to add, click on the “AKAs” checkbox. You will be prompted for the names later.



The screenshot shows a web form titled "Insert Data" with a close button in the top right corner. The form contains several input fields and checkboxes. An orange arrow points to the "AKAs" checkbox, which is checked. The "Appellant" checkbox is also checked, while "AOD" and "3 VLI Panel" are unchecked. The "Decision/Remand" radio button is selected. At the bottom, there are four buttons: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit".

Appellant's Name	JOHN DOE	☐ AOD
Claim Number	C XX XXX XX	☒ AKAs
Docket Number	XX-XX XXX	
Veteran's Name		☒ Appellant
Representative	Jane Jones, Attorney	
Signing VLI	JUDGE NAME	Lookup
Issues	3	☐ 3 VLI Panel
☒ Decision/Remand ☐ VHA ☐ IME		
My Cases Lookup Format Submit		

Adding Issues

The number of issues in a decision will be an important consideration, as the template supplies the basics of the decision. If you have more issues than identified in VACOLS, increase the number in the “Issues” input box.

Issues can be added or deleted directly in the IDT as well.

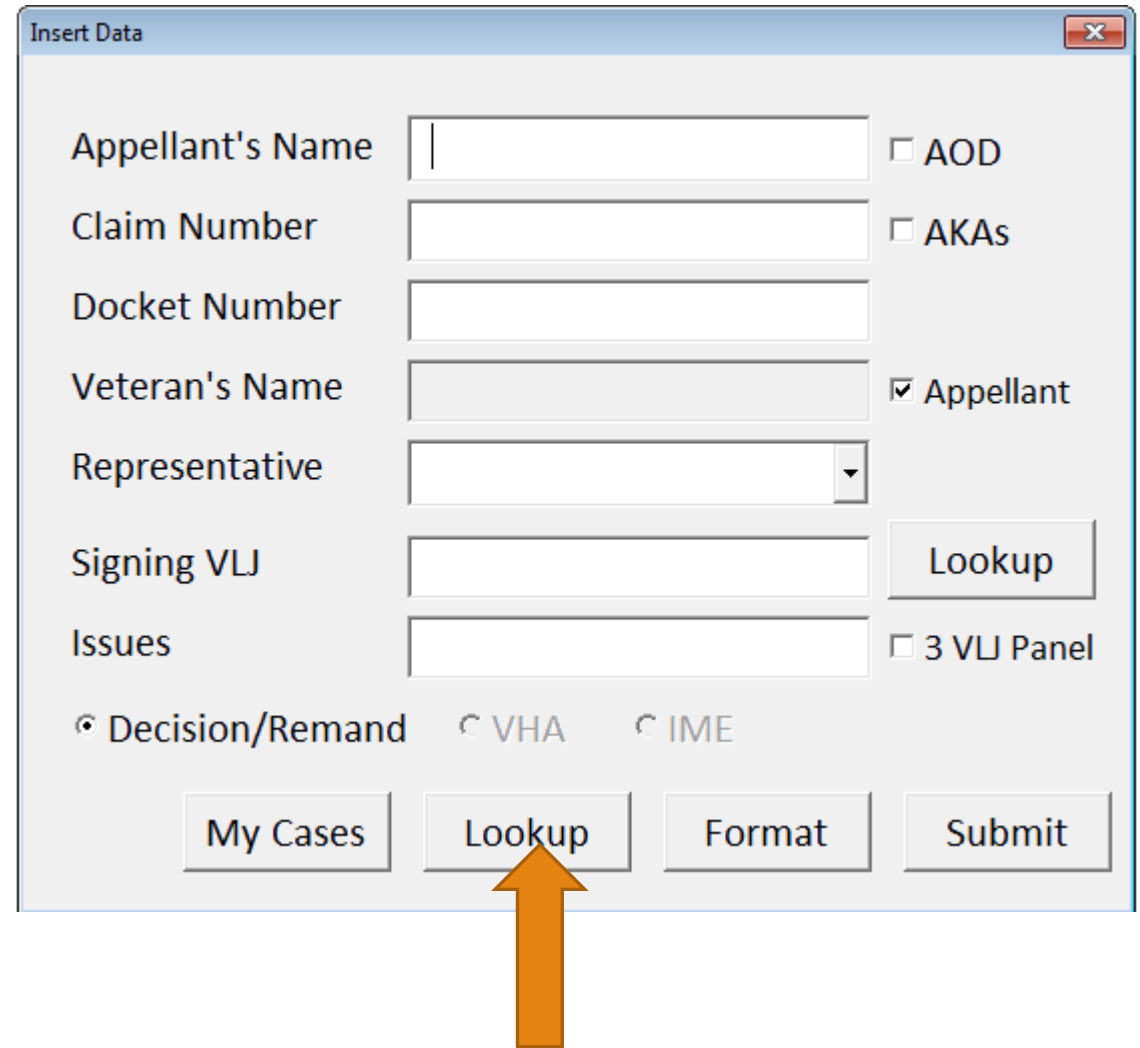
Note: Adding or deleting issues in the IDT does not update VACOLS.

Insert Data

Appellant's Name	JOHN DOE	☐ AOD
Claim Number	C XX XXX XX	☒ AKAs
Docket Number	XX-XX XXX	
Veteran's Name		☒ Appellant
Representative	Jane Jones, Attorney	
Signing VLJ	JUDGE NAME	Lookup
Issues	3	☒ 3 VLJ Panel
☒ Decision/Remand ☐ VHA ☐ IME		

My Cases **Lookup** Format Submit

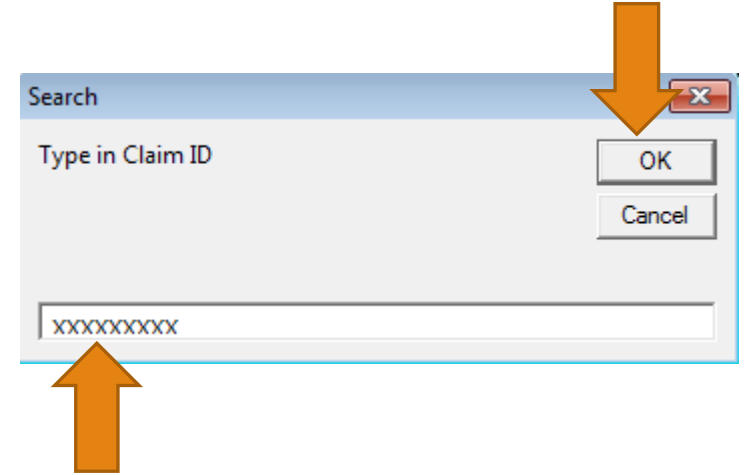
Populating the IDT with a case not assigned to you
If you need to write an opinion for a case that is not checked out to you, use the “Lookup” button on the bottom of the window.



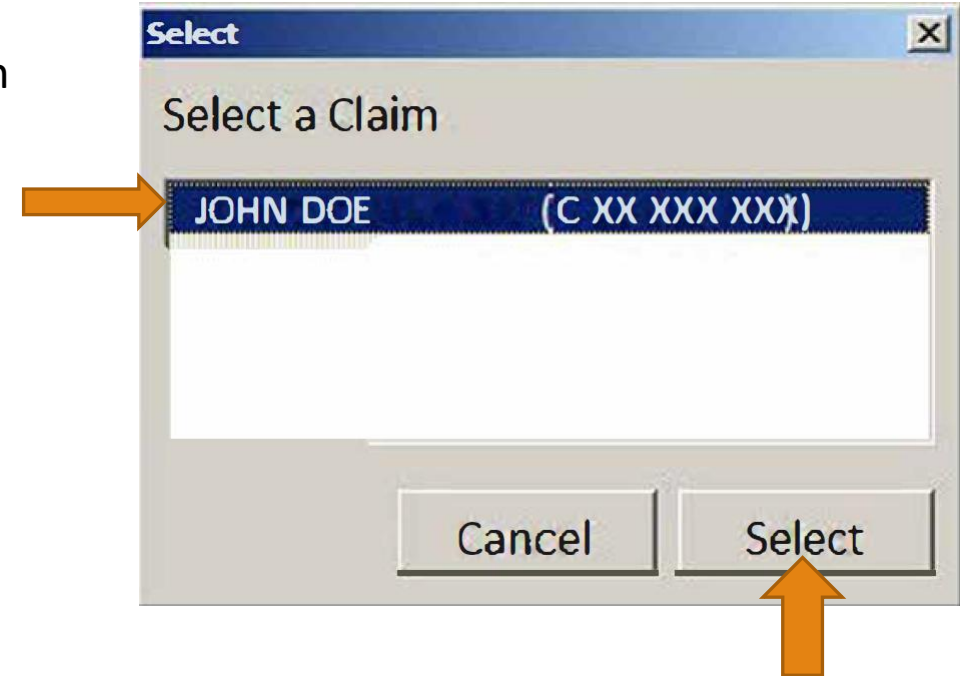
The screenshot shows a software window titled "Insert Data" with a standard Windows-style title bar (blue with a close button). The window contains several input fields and checkboxes. On the right side, there are checkboxes for "AOD", "AKAs", "Appellant", and "3 VLI Panel". The "Appellant" checkbox is checked. At the bottom, there are four buttons: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit". An orange arrow points directly to the "Lookup" button. The "Lookup" button is also present next to the "Signing VLI" field.

Appellant's Name		☐ AOD
Claim Number		☐ AKAs
Docket Number		
Veteran's Name		☒ Appellant
Representative		
Signing VLI		Lookup
Issues		☐ 3 VLI Panel
☒ Decision/Remand ☐ VHA ☐ IME		
My Cases Lookup Format Submit		

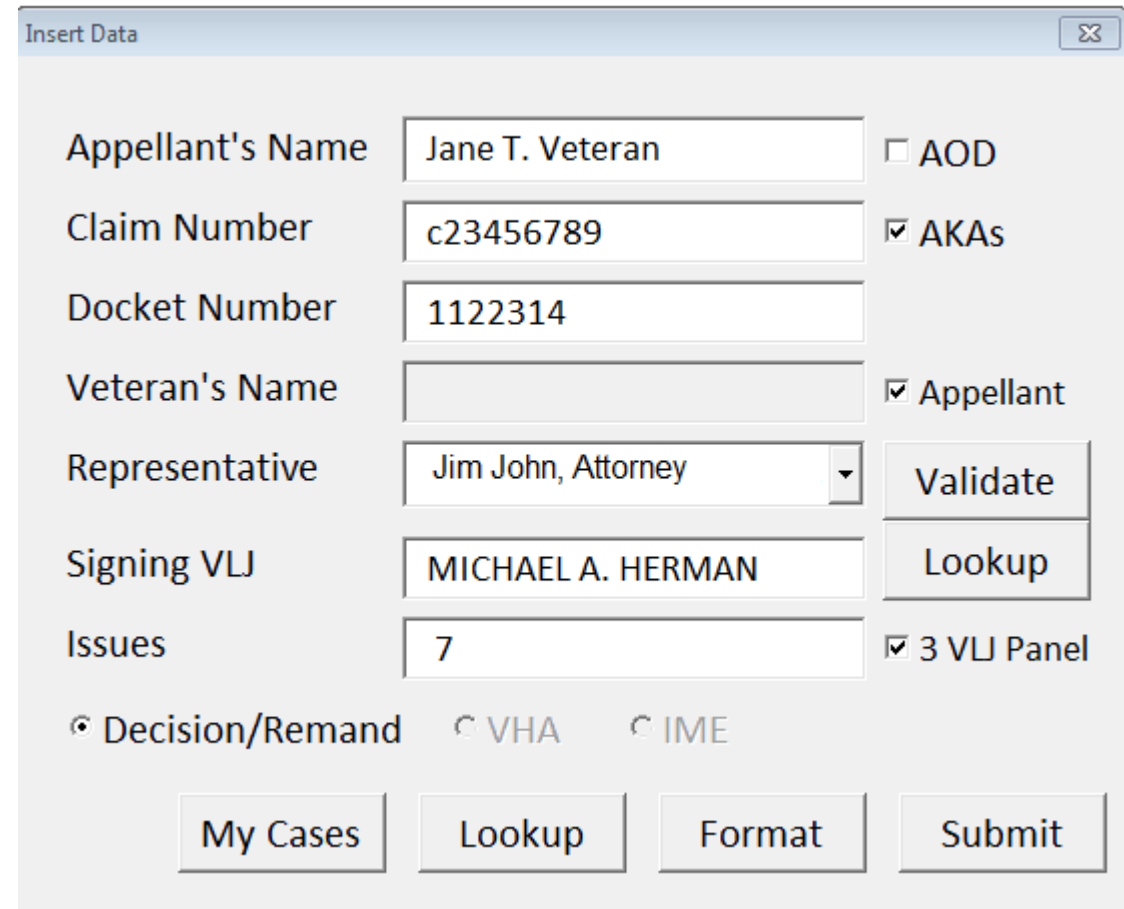
In the window that appears, type in the claim number (SS or C number) and then hit “OK.” The claim number does not need to be formatted correctly and it does not need the SS or C designation to be entered.



In the next window, click on the Veteran's name to highlight it, and then click on "Select".



You can make changes to the information entered in the form. You also don't need to worry about formatting. Simply make your changes and then click on the bottom "Format" button.



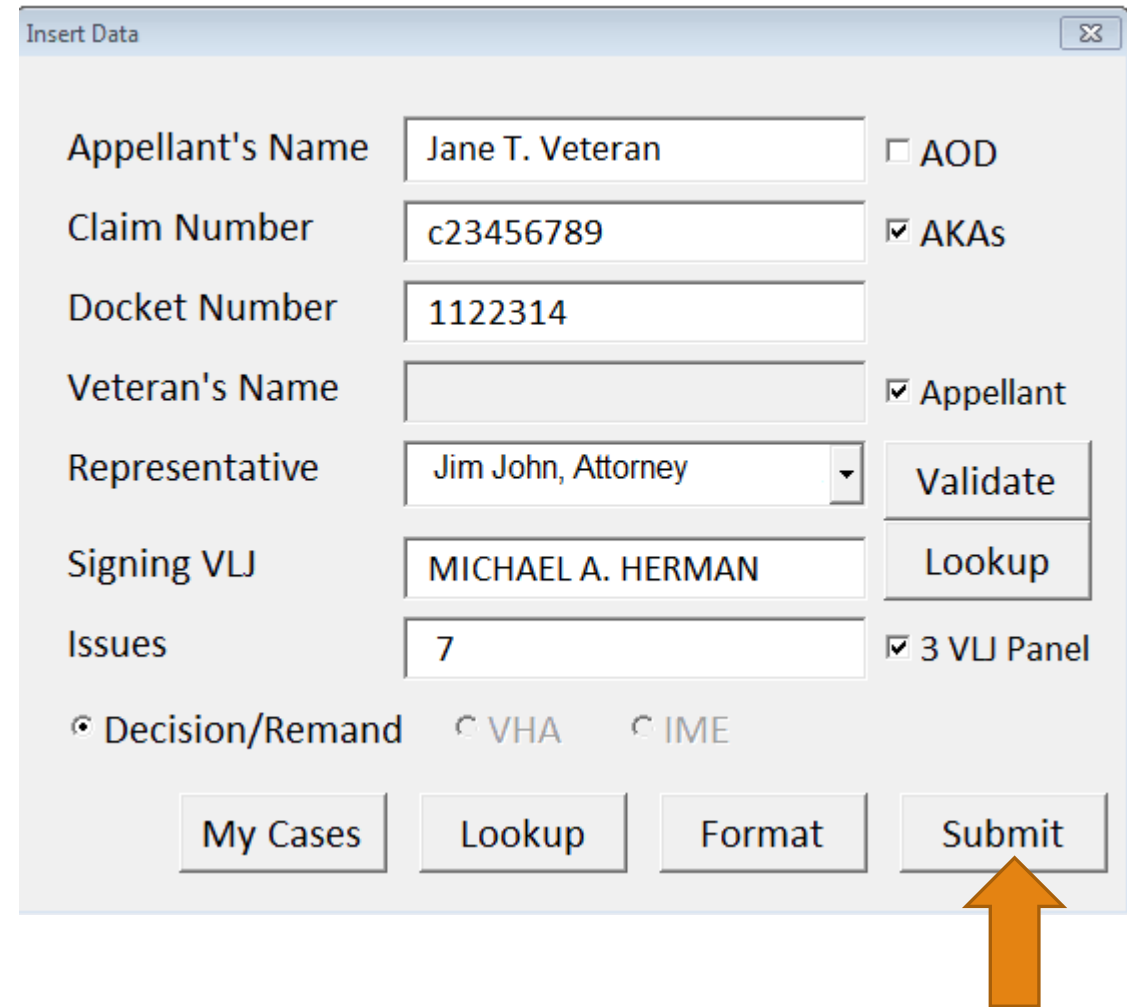
The screenshot shows a web form titled "Insert Data" with a close button in the top right corner. The form contains several input fields and checkboxes. The "Appellant's Name" field is filled with "Jane T. Veteran". The "Claim Number" field is filled with "c23456789". The "Docket Number" field is filled with "1122314". The "Veteran's Name" field is empty. The "Representative" field is a dropdown menu showing "Jim John, Attorney". The "Signing VLJ" field is filled with "MICHAEL A. HERMAN". The "Issues" field is filled with "7". There are three checkboxes on the right: "AOD" (unchecked), "AKAs" (checked), and "Appellant" (checked). There are also two buttons, "Validate" and "Lookup", to the right of the "Representative" and "Signing VLJ" fields respectively. At the bottom, there are four buttons: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit". An orange arrow points upwards to the "Format" button. Below the "Issues" field, there are three radio buttons: "Decision/Remand" (selected), "VHA", and "IME".

Appellant's Name	Jane T. Veteran	☐ AOD
Claim Number	c23456789	☒ AKAs
Docket Number	1122314	
Veteran's Name		☒ Appellant
Representative	Jim John, Attorney	Validate
Signing VLJ	MICHAEL A. HERMAN	Lookup
Issues	7	☒ 3 VLJ Panel

☒ Decision/Remand ☐ VHA ☐ IME

My Cases Lookup Format Submit

When you are satisfied, click “Submit”.

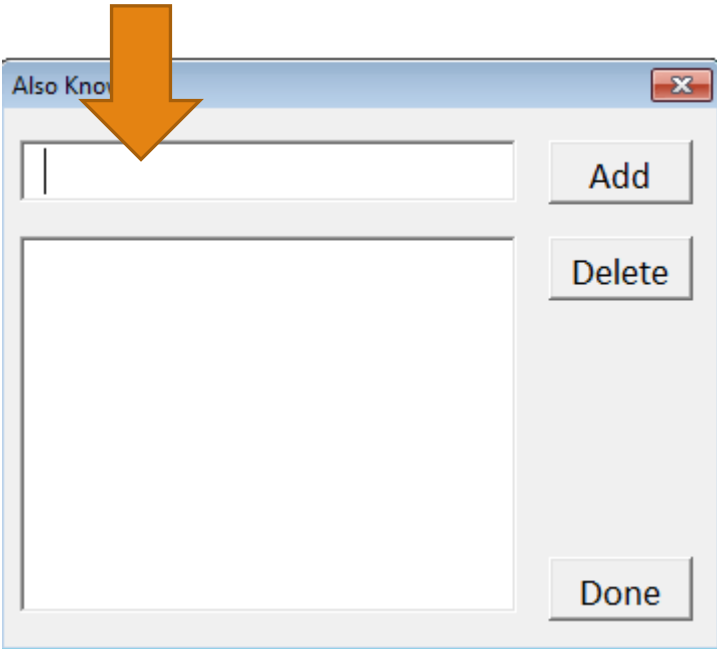


The screenshot shows a web form titled "Insert Data" with a close button in the top right corner. The form contains several input fields and checkboxes. The "Appellant's Name" field is filled with "Jane T. Veteran". The "Claim Number" field is filled with "c23456789". The "Docket Number" field is filled with "1122314". The "Veteran's Name" field is empty. The "Representative" field is a dropdown menu showing "Jim John, Attorney". The "Signing VLI" field is filled with "MICHAEL A. HERMAN". The "Issues" field is filled with "7". There are three checkboxes on the right: "AOD" (unchecked), "AKAs" (checked), and "Appellant" (checked). Below the "Representative" field are two buttons: "Validate" and "Lookup". Below the "Issues" field is a checkbox for "3 VLI Panel" which is checked. At the bottom, there are four radio buttons: "Decision/Remand" (selected), "VHA", and "IME". At the very bottom are four buttons: "My Cases", "Lookup", "Format", and "Submit". An orange arrow points to the "Submit" button.

Appellant's Name	Jane T. Veteran	☐ AOD
Claim Number	c23456789	☒ AKAs
Docket Number	1122314	
Veteran's Name		☒ Appellant
Representative	Jim John, Attorney	Validate
Signing VLI	MICHAEL A. HERMAN	Lookup
Issues	7	☒ 3 VLI Panel
☒ Decision/Remand ☐ VHA ☐ IME		
My Cases Lookup Format Submit		

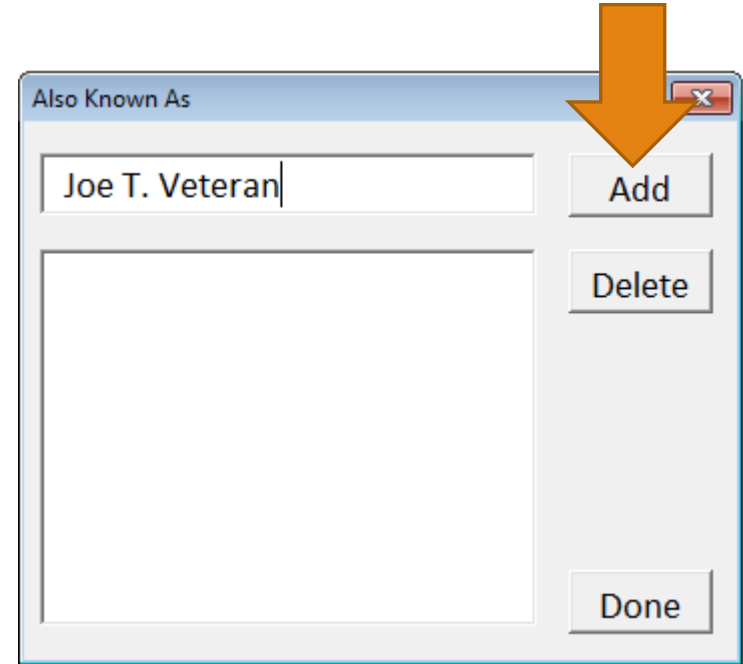
AKAs: Adding & Deleting Names

If you clicked the “AKAs” checkbox, you will see the window to the right. To add an AKA, type it into the top box and then click “Add”.



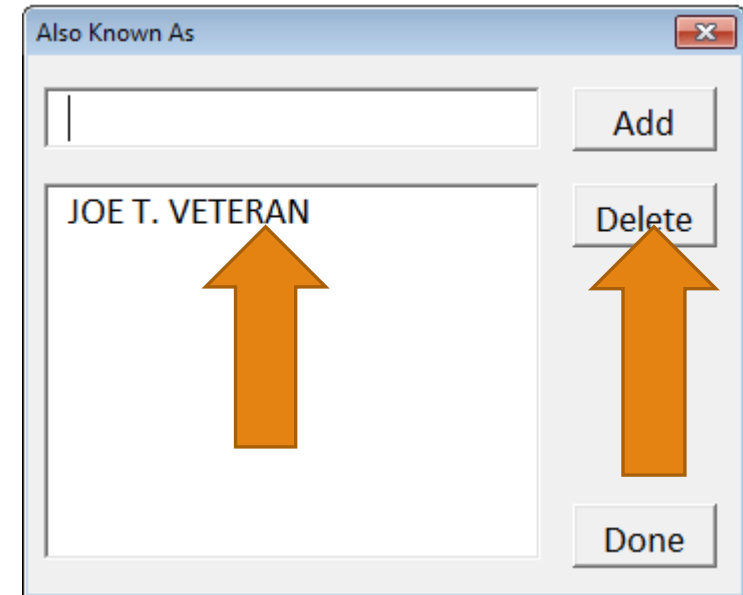
The screenshot shows a window titled "Also Known As" with a standard Windows-style title bar (blue with a close button). The window contains a text input field at the top, a large empty list box below it, and three buttons on the right: "Add", "Delete", and "Done". A large orange arrow points down to the text input field.

You don't have to capitalize the name, that will be done automatically.

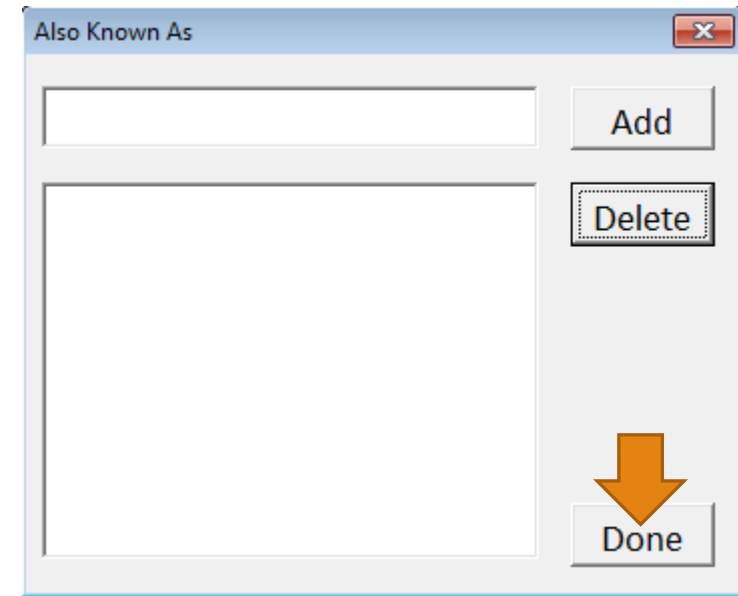


The image shows a Windows-style dialog box titled "Also Known As". It has a standard title bar with a close button (X) in the top right corner. The main area of the dialog contains a text input field with the text "Joe T. Veteran" and a large, empty rectangular box below it. To the right of the input field is an "Add" button, and below that is a "Delete" button. At the bottom right of the dialog is a "Done" button. A large orange arrow points down towards the "Add" button.

If you make a mistake, or otherwise wish to delete a name, click the name to highlight it, then click “Delete”.



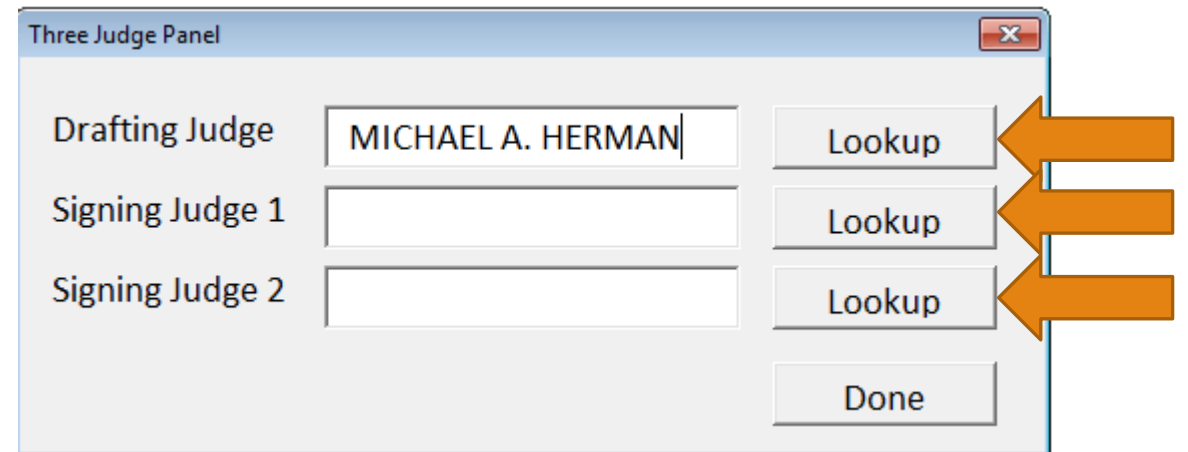
When you have finished adding names, click the “Done” button.



Panel Decision: Judge Selection

If you checked the “3 VLJ Panel” checkbox, you will see the following window. Click on the “Lookup” button next to each slot to find VLJ signatures.

The “Drafting Judge” is the bottom signature in the opinion.

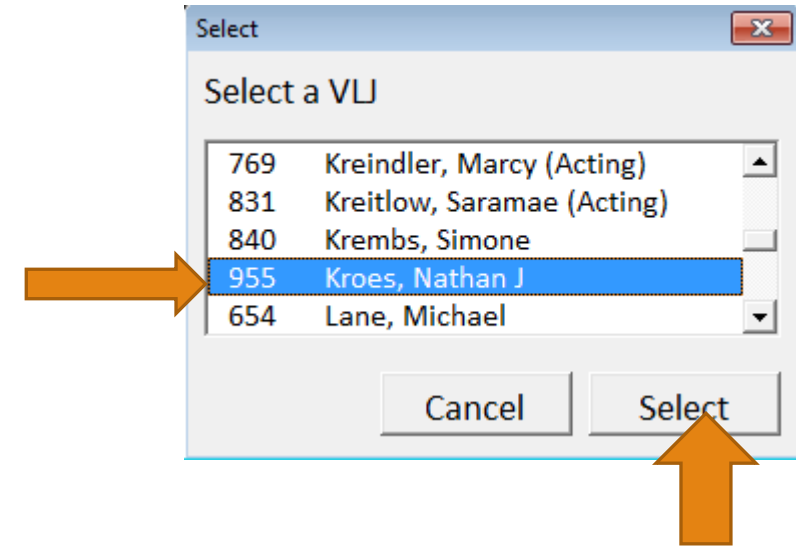


The screenshot shows a window titled "Three Judge Panel" with a close button (X) in the top right corner. The window contains three rows of input fields and buttons:

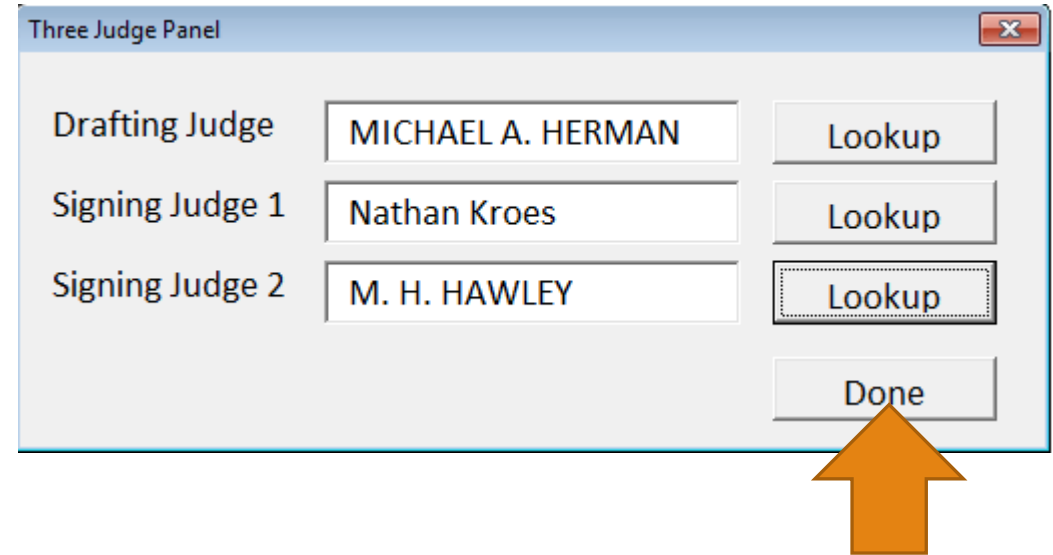
Role	Text Input	Action
Drafting Judge	MICHAEL A. HERMAN	Lookup
Signing Judge 1		Lookup
Signing Judge 2		Lookup

Below the "Lookup" buttons is a "Done" button. Three orange arrows point to the "Lookup" buttons for the Drafting Judge, Signing Judge 1, and Signing Judge 2.

Select VLJs the same way as on the main window:
scroll to a Judge, click to highlight their name, and
then click on “Select”.



When all of the Judges have been selected, click on the “Done” button.



The image shows a software dialog box titled "Three Judge Panel". It contains three rows of input fields for judge names, each with a "Lookup" button to its right. The first row is for the "Drafting Judge" with the name "MICHAEL A. HERMAN". The second row is for "Signing Judge 1" with the name "Nathan Kroes". The third row is for "Signing Judge 2" with the name "M. H. HAWLEY". Below these rows is a "Done" button. A large orange arrow points upwards to the "Done" button, indicating the final step in the process.

Judge Role	Judge Name	Action
Drafting Judge	MICHAEL A. HERMAN	Lookup
Signing Judge 1	Nathan Kroes	Lookup
Signing Judge 2	M. H. HAWLEY	Lookup

Done

Selecting Issue Outcomes

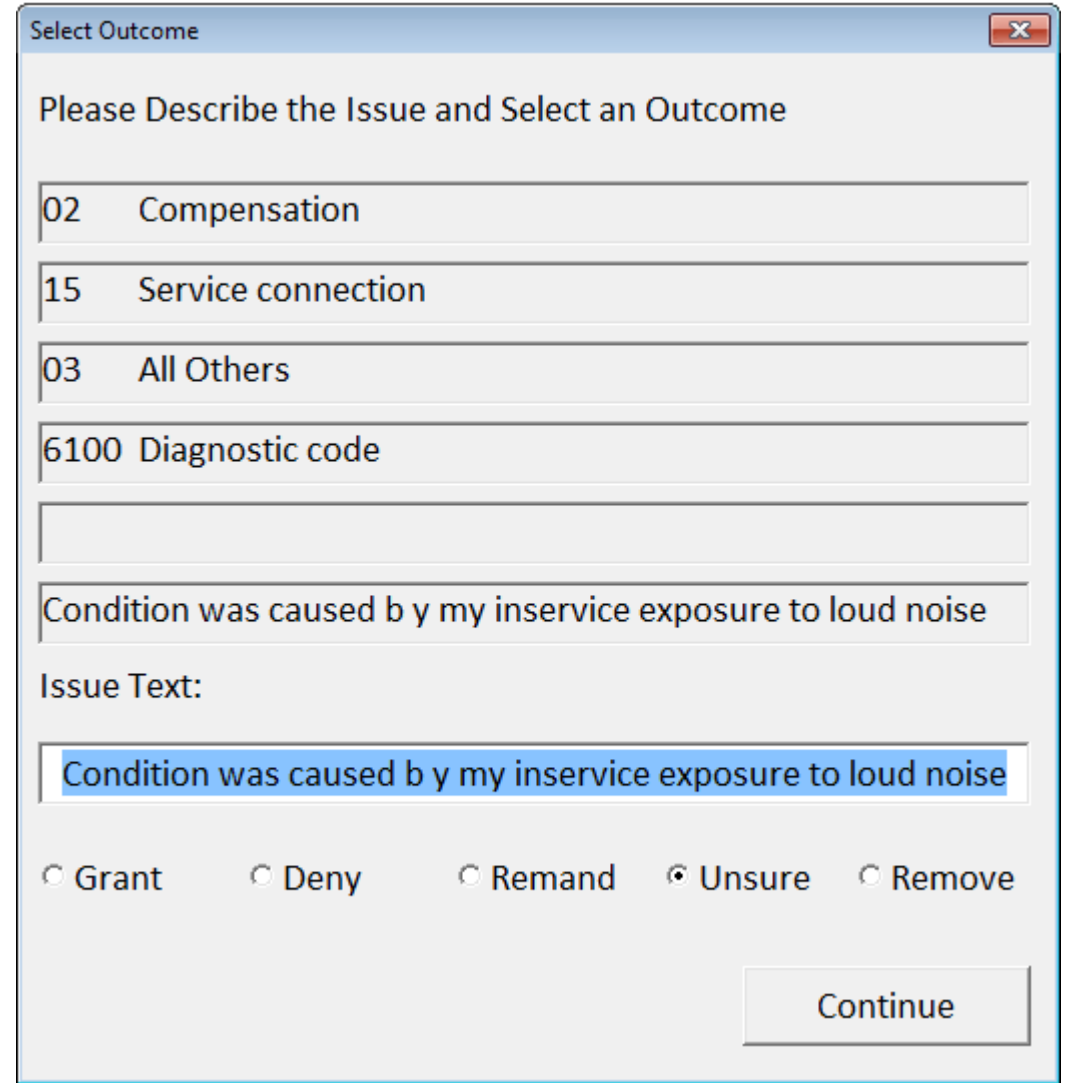
For each issue in the case, you will see one of these windows. The top boxes show the classification of the issue in VACOLS.

The “Issue Text” defaults to the RO’s comments, but it can be changed. It is important to have easily identifiable issue text (ie. hearing loss, or 30 percent for a left knee disability). This can be manually updated in the IDT.

Last, select one of the five radio buttons near the bottom. These buttons will determine how the issue is to be decided. You can use “Unsure” if you are unsure, and will be easy to switch between remanded and decided issues after the decision is populated.

Use “Remove” if you want to remove the issue from the decision completely. Issues can be added or deleted after the decision is populated.

When you are finished, click “Continue”.



The screenshot shows a window titled "Select Outcome" with a close button in the top right corner. The window contains the following elements:

- A header text: "Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome".
- A list of issue classifications with corresponding VACOLS codes in a table-like structure:

02	Compensation
15	Service connection
03	All Others
6100	Diagnostic code
- A text box containing the issue description: "Condition was caused b y my inservice exposure to loud noise".
- A label "Issue Text:" followed by a text box containing the same text: "Condition was caused b y my inservice exposure to loud noise".
- Five radio buttons for decision outcomes: "Grant", "Deny", "Remand", "Unsure" (which is selected), and "Remove".
- A "Continue" button at the bottom right.

Repeat the same actions for each issue.

Select Outcome

Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome

02 Compensation

15 Service connection

03 All Others

6260 Diagnostic code

I have been seen a VAMC for constant loud ringing of my ears

Issue Text:

I have been seen a VAMC for constant loud ringing of my ears

☒ Grant

☐ Deny

☐ Remand

☐ Unsure

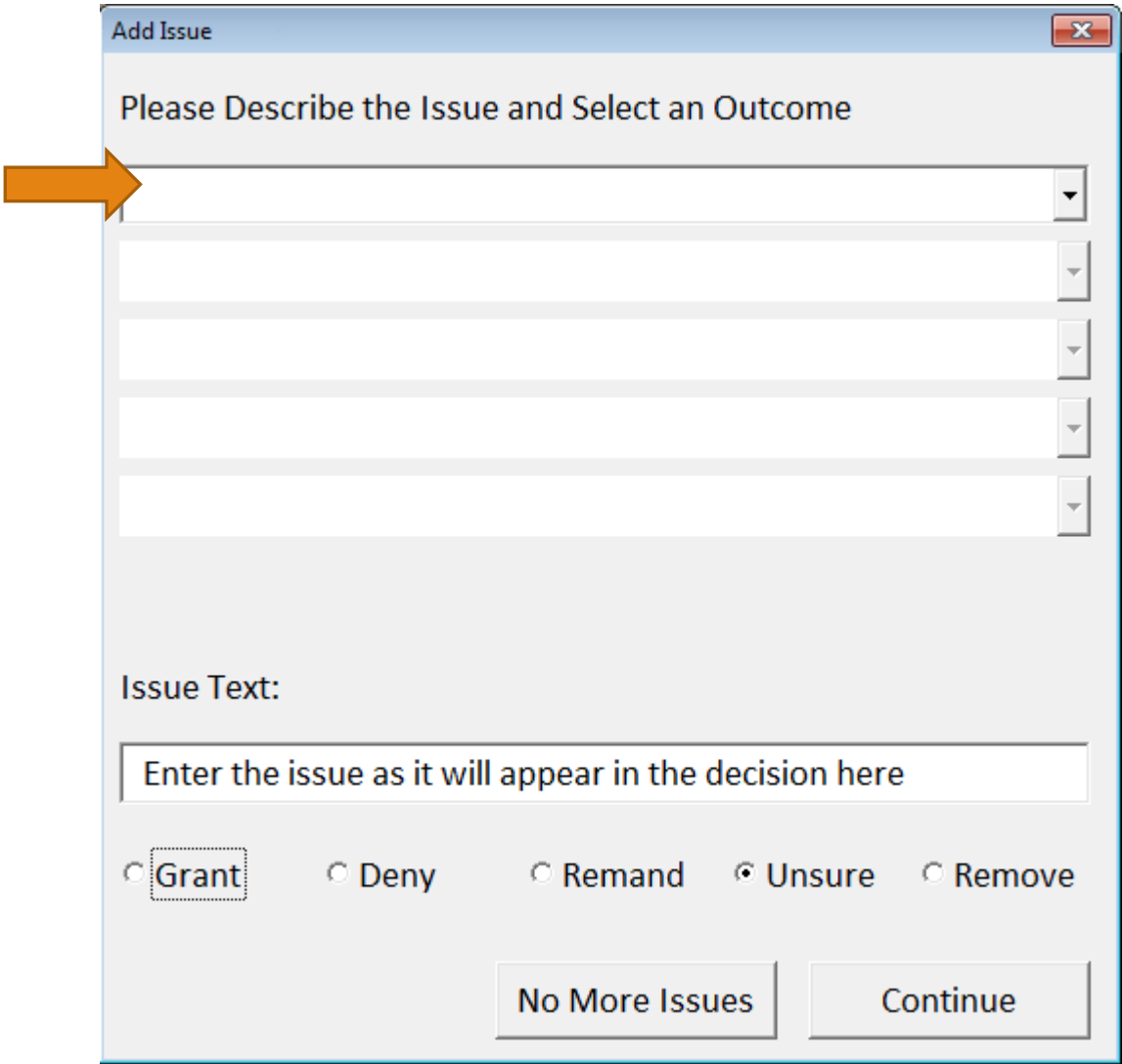
☐ Remove

Continue

Creating issue text for additional issues

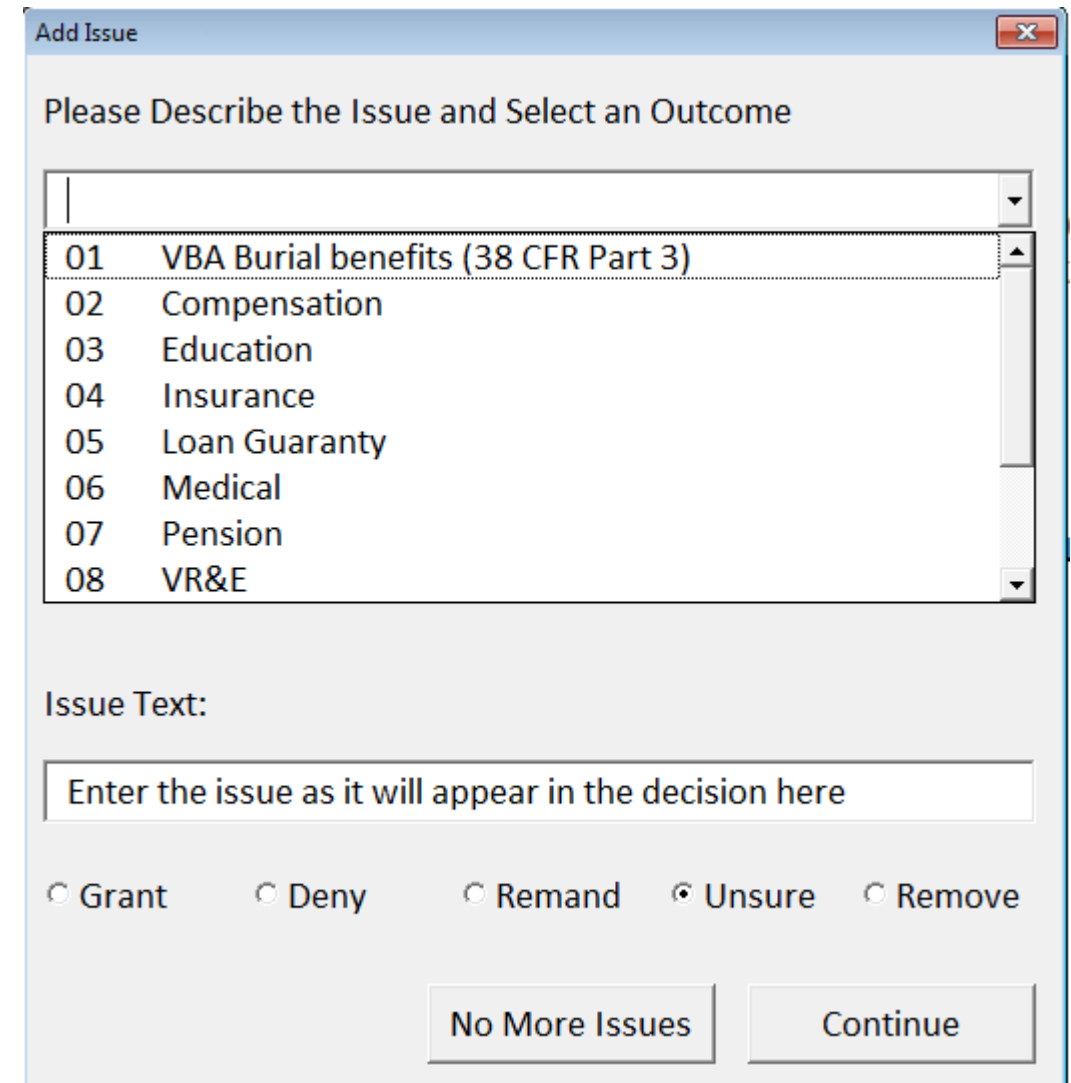
If you increased the number of issues on the first screen, you will be presented with this window asking you to categorize your new issue.

First, click on the top most drop-down to select the Program.



The screenshot shows a window titled "Add Issue" with a close button in the top right corner. Below the title bar, the text "Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome" is displayed. There are five horizontal drop-down menus stacked vertically. An orange arrow points to the first (top) drop-down menu. Below these menus, the text "Issue Text:" is followed by a text input field containing the placeholder text "Enter the issue as it will appear in the decision here". At the bottom, there are five radio button options: "Grant", "Deny", "Remand", "Unsure", and "Remove". The "Grant" option is selected and has a dotted border around its label. At the bottom right, there are two buttons: "No More Issues" and "Continue".

Here, we will select “Compensation” as an example.



The screenshot shows a dialog box titled "Add Issue" with a close button in the top right corner. The main instruction is "Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome". Below this is a list box containing eight items, each with a number and a description. Item 02, "Compensation", is selected. Below the list box is a text field labeled "Issue Text:" with the placeholder text "Enter the issue as it will appear in the decision here". At the bottom, there are five radio buttons for selecting an outcome: "Grant", "Deny", "Remand", "Unsure" (which is selected), and "Remove". At the very bottom are two buttons: "No More Issues" and "Continue".

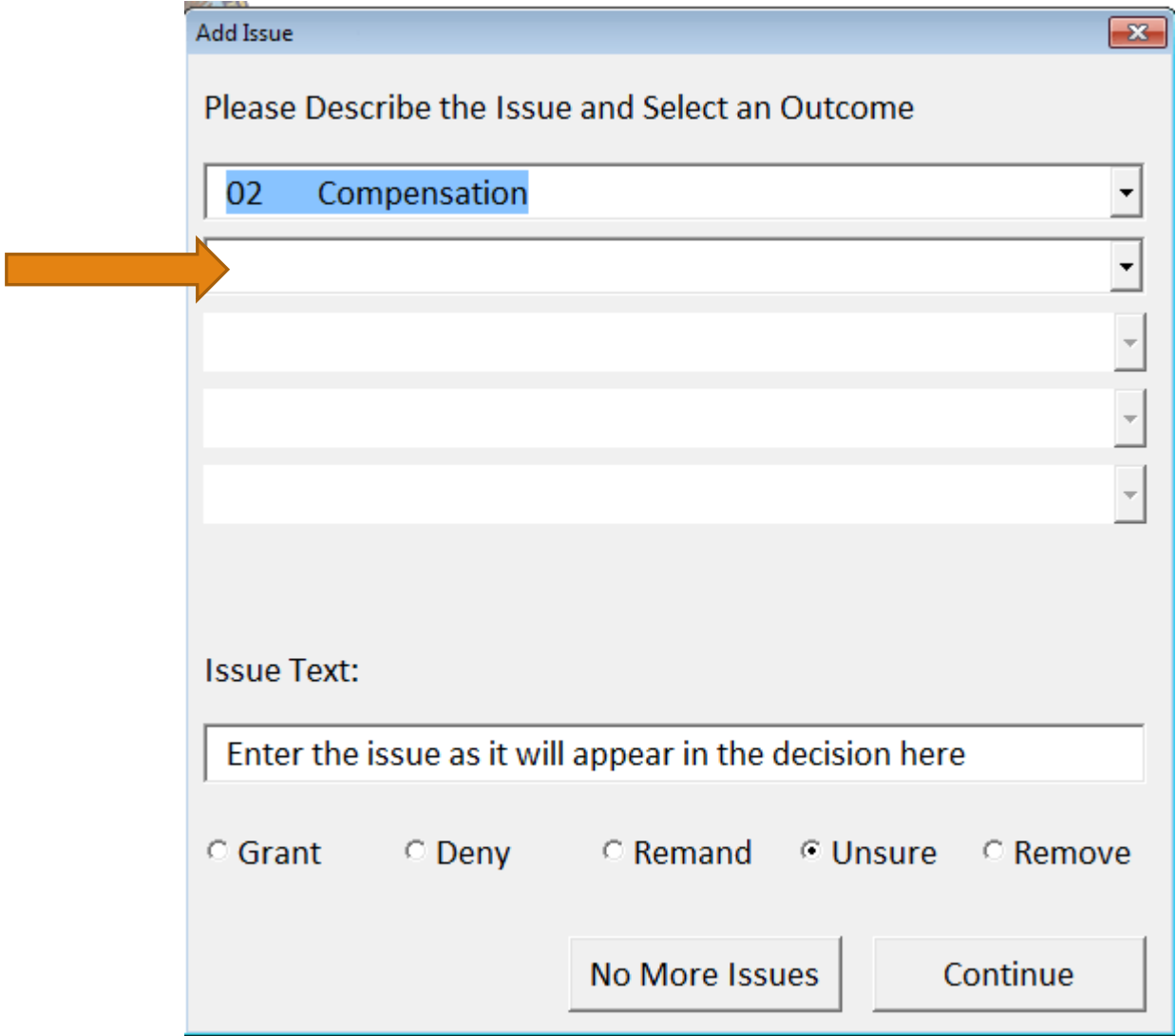
Issue ID	Issue Description
01	VBA Burial benefits (38 CFR Part 3)
02	Compensation
03	Education
04	Insurance
05	Loan Guaranty
06	Medical
07	Pension
08	VR&E

Issue Text:

Enter the issue as it will appear in the decision here

☐ Grant ☐ Deny ☐ Remand ☒ Unsure ☐ Remove

Continue down the drop-downs to select sub issues.



The screenshot shows a software window titled "Add Issue" with a close button in the top right corner. The window contains the instruction "Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome". Below this, there is a series of five drop-down menus. The first menu is open, showing the selection "02 Compensation". An orange arrow points to the second, empty drop-down menu. Below the drop-downs is a text area labeled "Issue Text:" with the placeholder text "Enter the issue as it will appear in the decision here". At the bottom, there are five radio button options: "Grant", "Deny", "Remand", "Unsure" (which is selected), and "Remove". In the bottom right corner, there are two buttons: "No More Issues" and "Continue".

Add Issue

Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome

02 Compensation

17 TDIU

Issue Text:

Enter the issue as it will appear in the decision here

☐ Grant

☐ Deny

☐ Remand

☒ Unsure

☐ Remove

No More Issues

Continue

Continue until you either run out of drop-down menus or the drop-down menu is empty.



Add Issue

Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome

02 Compensation

17 TDIU

02 Entitlement

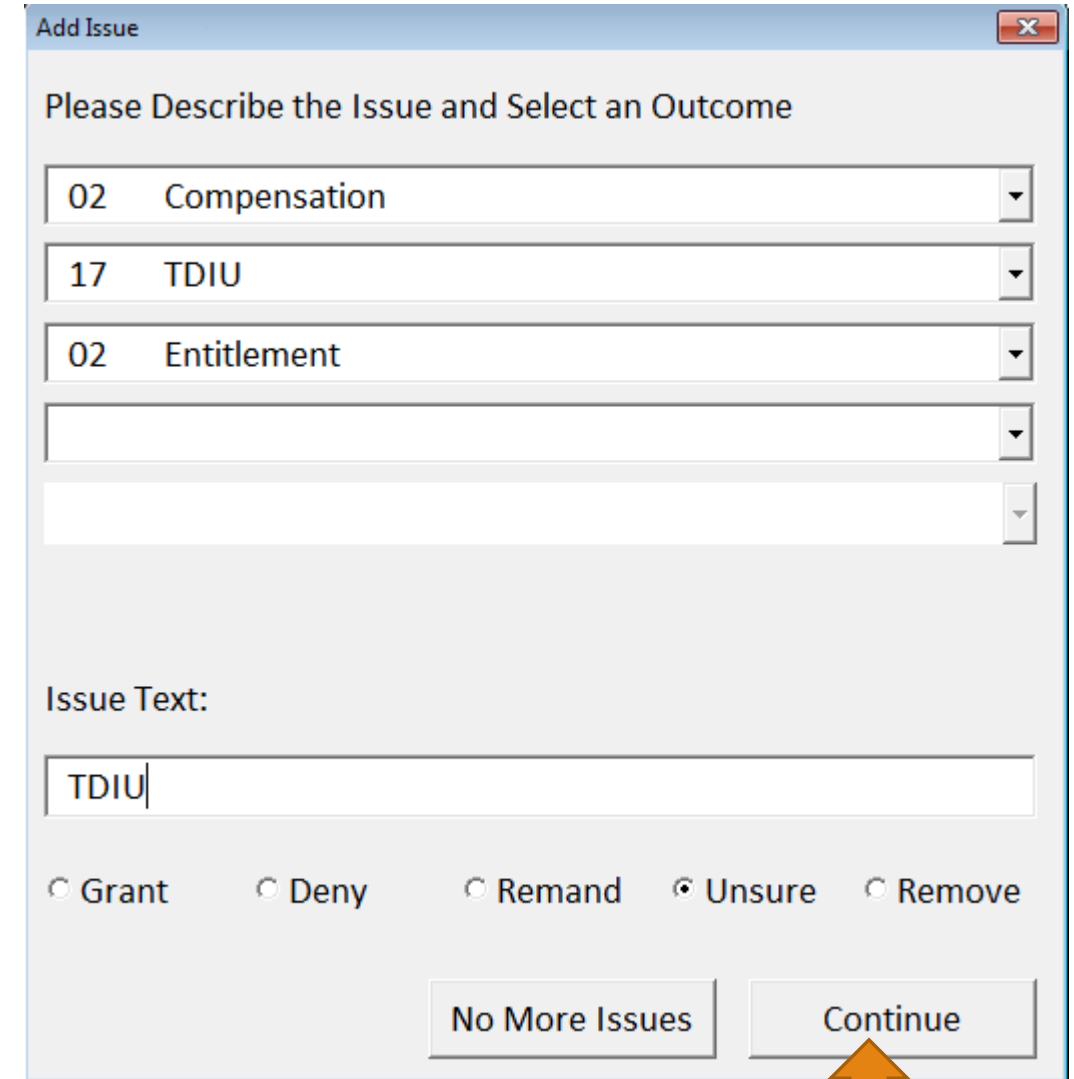
Issue Text:

Enter the issue as it will appear in the decision here

☐ Grant ☐ Deny ☐ Remand ☒ Unsure ☐ Remove

No More Issues Continue

Enter the Issue Text as before and select one of the radio buttons near the bottom. The click on “Continue”.



The screenshot shows a web form titled "Add Issue" with a close button in the top right corner. The form contains the following elements:

- A heading: "Please Describe the Issue and Select an Outcome"
- Four dropdown menus. The first three are populated with "02 Compensation", "17 TDIU", and "02 Entitlement" respectively. The fourth dropdown is empty.
- A text input field labeled "Issue Text:" containing the text "TDIU".
- A row of five radio buttons with labels: "Grant", "Deny", "Remand", "Unsure", and "Remove". The "Unsure" radio button is selected.
- Two buttons at the bottom right: "No More Issues" and "Continue".

A large orange arrow points upwards from the bottom of the page towards the "Continue" button.

After completing all of the issues, the template will take a moment to process, and then generate the framework for your decision. If Microsoft Word greys out and says “Not Responding” just wait a moment and it should respond. This can be a problem on slower computers.



BOARD OF VETERANS' APPEALS

DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS

IN THE APPEAL OF
JOHN DOE
REPRESENTED BY
Representative

C XX XXX XXX
Docket No. XX-XX XXX
Advanced on the Docket

DATE: 11 January 2018
ISSUES DECIDED: 1 ISSUES REMANDED: 0

ORDER

Entitlement to service connection for renal cell carcinoma is granted.

FINDING OF FACT

It is at least as likely as not that the Veteran's renal cell carcinoma was caused by his exposure to Agent Orange during service.

CONCLUSION OF LAW

The criteria for service connection for renal cell carcinoma have been satisfied. 38 U.S.C. §§ 1110, 1116, 5107 (2014); 38 C.F.R. §§ 3.102, 3.303, 3.307, 3.309 (2017).

REASONS AND BASES FOR FINDING AND CONCLUSION

The Veteran served on active duty in the United States Army from April 1966 to April 1969, including service in the Republic of Vietnam.